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DURING THE SAME VISIT to my bedside at Bethesda Naval Hospital on July 18, 1985, at which he informed me a group of Iranian moderates wanted to open a dialogue with American officials leading to possible improvement in our relations and release of our hostages in Beirut, Bud McFarlane told me Mikhail Gorbachev had sent word endorsing a proposal I'd made suggesting that before the summit the two of us continue our direct and private communications. "We tried to get such a thing with his predecessors and couldn't make it," I mentioned in the diary. "I gave the word to proceed."

Meanwhile, we were starting to see indications of other changes in the Kremlin—although we still didn't know yet what they signified.

Two weeks earlier, Gorbachev had arranged for Andrei Gromyko to be designated president of the USSR, a purely ceremonial job that ended Gromyko's twenty-eight-year career as foreign minister.

His successor was Eduard A. Shevardnadze, a Communist Party official from the Soviet republic of Georgia about whom we knew relatively little. In late July, George Shultz flew to Finland to meet Shevardnadze and make arrangements for the upcoming summit. Calling from Helsinki on a secure phone, George told me his instinctive reaction to the new Soviet foreign minister was positive: He was tough, but less hostile and more personable than Gromyko.

After the plans for the summit were announced, I told the White House staff and cabinet to do nothing that would